

HaulCheck — Local Setup Guide

Installing and running HaulCheck on a Windows laptop, step by step.

This guide is written so you can follow it yourself, or read it out while guiding the client over AnyDesk. Every command is copy-and-paste. Nothing here touches the internet-facing production setup — this gets the app running ****on the laptop itself****, which is all that is needed to demo it, enter real data, and use it day to day.

Assumptions: a **Windows 10 or 11** laptop with administrator rights and a normal internet connection. Budget **30–45 minutes** the first time, most of which is downloads. If the client is on a **Mac**, stop here and ask for the Mac version of this guide — the commands are different.

What you are installing, and why

HaulCheck has three parts that run on the laptop together:

Part	What it is	You will install
Database	Stores all the fleet, driver and compliance data	MongoDB 7 (runs quietly in the background)
API / backend	The engine — logins, compliance rules, PDFs	Python 3.12 + the app's code
Web app / frontend	The screens you click on in the browser	Node.js + the app's code

You also need two tools to get the code and run it: **Git** (downloads the code) and the installers below. Do the steps **in order** — each one builds on the last.

Step 1 — Install the four tools

Download and install these four, one at a time. The ****install options in bold matter**** — getting them wrong is the most common cause of problems later.

1a. Git (downloads the code)

- Download: <<https://git-scm.com/download/win>> (the download starts on its own).
- Run the installer. **Click Next through every screen** — the defaults are fine.

1b. Python 3.12 (runs the backend)

- Download: <<https://www.python.org/downloads/release/python-31210/>> — scroll to the bottom and choose **“Windows installer (64-bit)”**.

- ⚠️ **Do not** install Python 3.13 or 3.14 — some of the app's parts do not work on those yet. It must be **3.12**.

- On the very first installer screen, **tick the box “Add python.exe to PATH”** at the bottom, *then* click **Install Now**. This one tick saves a lot of trouble.

1c. Node.js (runs the web app)

- Download: <<https://nodejs.org/en/download>> — choose the **LTS** version, Windows Installer (.msi).

- Run it and click Next through the defaults. If it offers a checkbox about “automatically install the necessary tools,” you can **leave it unticked** — it is not needed.

1d. MongoDB 7 (the database)

- Download: <<https://www.mongodb.com/try/download/community>> — set **Version** to **7.0, Platform** Windows, **Package** msi, then **Download**.

- Run the installer:
- Choose **“Complete”** setup.
- On the service screen, leave **“Install MongoDB as a Service”** ticked (this is the default). This means the database **starts automatically** every time the laptop is turned on — the client never has to think about it.

- Leave **“Install MongoDB Compass”** ticked — it is a free visual tool for looking at the data, handy but optional.

Check they all installed

Open a **new** PowerShell window (click Start, type `PowerShell`, press Enter) and run these one at a time. Each should print a version number:

```
git --version
py -3.12 --version
node --version
```

If any says **“not recognised”**, that tool did not install correctly — re-run its installer (for Python, the missing **“Add to PATH”** tick is almost always the cause).

Step 2 — Download the app's code

In the same PowerShell window, choose where the code should live and clone it. This puts it in the user's home folder under `haulcheck` :

```
cd ~  
git clone https://github.com/shahmir2004/haulcheck.git
```

A browser window will pop up asking you to sign in to GitHub. The code is in a **private** repository, so sign in with **your own developer GitHub account** (the one that owns the repo). This happens once; Git remembers it afterwards.

When it finishes, move into the app folder. The app lives two levels down inside the project:

```
cd ~\haulcheck\emergent app\Haulcheck-main
```

You are now in the folder that contains `backend` , `frontend` and `start-haulcheck.bat` . Every command below is run from here unless it says otherwise.

Step 3 — Set up the backend

This creates a private Python environment for the app and installs its parts.

```
cd backend  
py -3.12 -m venv .venv  
.venv\Scripts\python -m pip install -r requirements-local.txt
```

The install takes a couple of minutes. Then create the app's settings file from the template:

```
Copy-Item .env.example .env
```

One value must be filled in: a secret key used to keep logins secure. Generate one and open the file to paste it in:

```
.venv\Scripts\python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_urlsafe(48))"  
notepad .env
```

In Notepad, find the line that starts `JWT_SECRET=` and replace the placeholder with the long random string that was just printed. For example:

```
JWT_SECRET=Xy8 ... the-long-random-string-you-copied ...
```

Save and close Notepad. **Leave every other line as it is** — the defaults are correct for running on the laptop. (The keys for AI, email and Google sign-in are left blank on purpose; the app runs fine without them. See **Optional extras** at the end if you want to switch those on.)

Step 4 — Set up the web app

Go back up to the app folder and into `frontend` :

```
cd ..\frontend
corepack enable
corepack prepare yarn@1.22.22 --activate
yarn install
```

`yarn install` downloads a lot of small files and can take **3–5 minutes** — this is normal. Then create its settings file (the defaults are correct as-is, no editing needed):

```
Copy-Item .env.example .env
```

Step 5 — Start it for the first time

Everything is installed. Now start the two parts. The database is already running in the background as a service, so there is nothing to start for it.

Easiest way — the launcher: in File Explorer, open `...\haulcheck\emergent app\Haulcheck-main` , and ****double-click `start-haulcheck.bat` ****. Two black windows open (the API and the web app), and after a few seconds your browser opens the app automatically.

Or by hand — two PowerShell windows, from the app folder:

```
# Window 1 – the API
cd backend
.venv\Scripts\python -m uvicorn server:app --port 8000
```

```
# Window 2 – the web app
cd frontend
yarn start
```

The first time, the web app takes **30–60 seconds** to compile, then opens `<http://localhost:3000>` in the browser. If it does not open on its own, type that address in the browser yourself.

Leave both black windows open while using the app. They are the engine — closing one stops that part. To shut HaulCheck down at the end of the day, just close both windows.

Create the first account

1. On the login screen, choose **Register / Create account**.
2. Enter the client's company details and a password. ****The password must be at least 12 characters**** (this is a deliberate security rule).

1. That first account becomes the owner of the organisation. Everyone else the client adds later (managers, drivers) is invited from inside the app.

That's it — the app is running. Add a vehicle, log a defect, generate a PDF audit pack to confirm everything works.

Step 6 — Using it day to day

After the one-time setup above, starting HaulCheck each day is simple:

- The **database** is already running (it starts with Windows — nothing to do).
- **Double-click** `start-haulcheck.bat`, wait for the browser to open, and use it.
- When finished, **close the two black windows**.

You may want to ****right-click** `start-haulcheck.bat` → Send to → Desktop (create shortcut)** so the client has a one-click icon on the desktop.

Step 7 — Optional extras (only if the client wants them)

The app is fully usable without these. Each one switches on an **extra** feature and needs an account **in the client's name**. To turn one on, put its key into `backend\.env` (the file you edited in Step 3) and restart the API window.

Feature	What it adds	Where to get the key
AI assistant	Auto-summarises defects, drafts letters, reads insurance & tacho docs	An Anthropic API key — set <code>AI_PROVIDER=anthropic</code> and <code>ANTHROPIC_API_KEY=</code>
Email	Sends reminders, alerts and audit packs by email	A Resend account — set <code>RESEND_API_KEY=</code> and <code>SENDER_EMAIL=</code>
Google sign-in	“Sign in with Google” button	A Google Cloud OAuth client — set <code>GOOGLE_CLIENT_ID=</code> and <code>GOOGLE_CLIENT_SECRET=</code>
File storage	Photo/document uploads on defects and walkarounds	An S3-compatible bucket — set <code>STORAGE_PROVIDER=s3</code> and the <code>S3_*</code> values

Full details for each, including the exact account steps, are in the separate **HANDOVER** document. Until a key is added, that one feature simply shows as “not configured” and the rest of the app works normally.

Troubleshooting

The browser shows “can't reach this page” or the app won't load. The web app window is still compiling (wait for it to say *Compiled successfully*), or the API window isn't running. Both black windows must be open.

Everything loads but login/registration fails or spins. The API window isn't running or crashed. Look at the API window for a red error. The most common cause is a missing `JWT_SECRET` — re-check Step 3.

`py -3.12` says “not recognised”. Python 3.12 isn't installed or wasn't added to PATH. Re-run its installer and make sure “Add python.exe to PATH” is ticked (Step 1b).

`ServerSelectionTimeoutError` in the API window. The database isn't running. Open Start → type `services.msc` → find **MongoDB Server in the list → right-click → Start**. (It should be set to start automatically; if not, set its Startup type to Automatic.)

Port already in use / “address already in use”. An old copy is still running. Close all the black windows and double-click the launcher again. If it persists, restart the laptop.

`yarn` says “not recognised”. Run `corepack enable` again (Step 4), or close and reopen PowerShell so it picks up Node.

Where the data lives, and backups

- All the client's data is stored by MongoDB on the laptop (by default under

`C:\Program Files\MongoDB\Server\7.0\data`).

- Because this runs on one laptop, **there is no automatic off-machine backup**.

If long-term safety matters, the simplest option is to host the database in **MongoDB Atlas** (free tier) and point `MONGO_URL` in `backend\.env` at it — Atlas then handles backups. This is covered in the [HANDOVER](#) document.

- To move HaulCheck to a different laptop later, install the four tools there,

clone the code again, and copy the database across (or use Atlas, in which case there is nothing to copy).

Once the app is open in the browser and the first account is created, setup is complete. Keep this guide with the project for the next time it needs installing.